

CYBERSECURITY INCIDENT RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

**A Practical Framework for Detecting, Containing, and
Recovering from Cybersecurity Incidents**

Cybersecurity Internship Project

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1. ABSTRACT

Incident Response is a part of cybersecurity that aids organizations in identifying, analyzing, containing, and recovering from security incidents. A good incident response process aids in limiting the damage caused by an incident and assists organizations in restoring normal operations.

This project proposes a cybersecurity incident response playbook that helps in handling a security incident from its detection through post-incident assessment. The playbook covers the stages involved in an incident response process, which include preparation, detection/identification, triage, containment, eradication, recovery, and lessons learned.

Phishing-based account compromise scenario is adopted as a case study to illustrate how the incident will be handled with the aid of the playbook. This project also addresses issues on evidence collection, incident severity rating, communication and escalation process, and incident response checklist.

The primary aim of this project is to show how an effective incident response process can assist security personnel in responding to incidents in a systematic and efficient manner.

2. OBJECTIVES

1. For gaining knowledge about basics of cybersecurity incident response.
2. For gaining knowledge about various phases of incident response lifecycle.
3. For developing a systematic method to deal with cybersecurity incidents.
4. For understanding ways in which security incidents can be detected and recognized.
5. For understanding the process of incident triaging and classification.
6. For studying the methods of containment, eradication, and recovery.
7. For understanding the significance of evidence gathering during an incident.
8. For defining the procedures for communication and escalation in case of security incidents.
9. For developing an incident response checklist.
10. For understanding the significance of post-incident analysis.

3. INTRODUCTION

Cybersecurity incidents can occur due to many factors such as phishing, malware, unauthorized access, data breaches, and other malicious activities. In case of the incorrect handling of such cybersecurity incidents, they may have negative impacts on the confidentiality, integrity, and availability of information and systems.

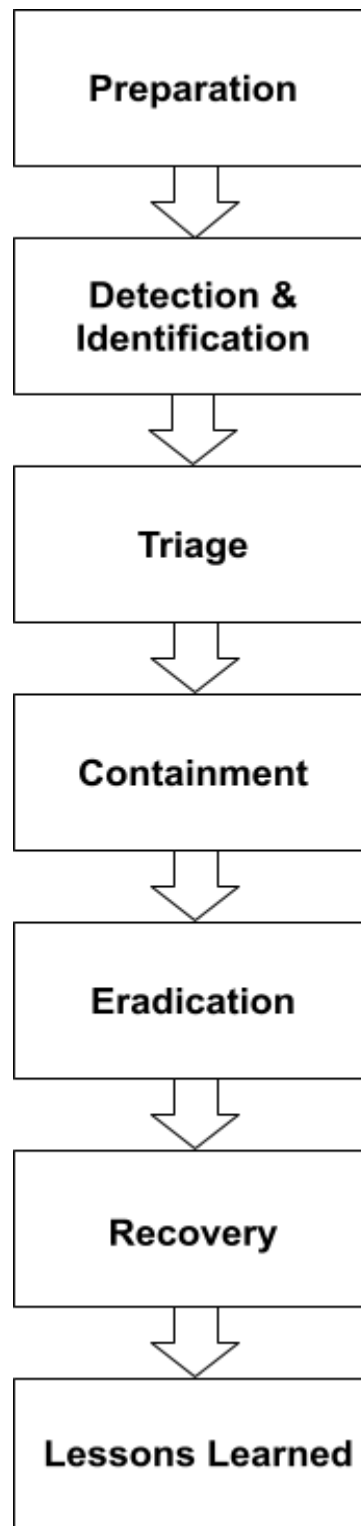
The concept of incident response includes identification and management of cybersecurity incidents in a systematic way. This concept offers a systematic approach which helps security teams understand the incident that has occurred, mitigate its effects, remove the root cause of the incident, and recover affected information systems.

An incident response playbook is a set of predefined actions that can be followed during cybersecurity incidents. The use of playbooks helps reduce the level of confusion that occurs during such situations and ensures the execution of activities such as gathering evidence, containing incidents, communicating with other parties, and recovery.

In this project, an account compromise scenario caused by phishing is considered to show how the incident response process should be executed.

4. INCIDENT RESPONSE LIFECYCLE

The lifecycle of incident response is made up of several different stages through which a business can manage a cybersecurity incident in an organized way. Every stage has its own purpose and helps reduce the negative consequences of the incident.



4.1 Preparation

Preparation entails creating the needed resources, processes, and responsibilities that will be needed for responding to a cyber security event. These include setting up an incident response team, having security tools ready, backups, communications, and response processes in place.

4.2 Detection and Identification

At this stage, detection of any unusual or suspicious behavior occurs to determine whether there is an actual incident. Security alert systems, reporting from users, authentication logs, email security programs, and others can help in finding out what happened.

4.3 Triage

The process of triage is carried out to assess the type and seriousness of the incident. The response team carries out an assessment of the systems, accounts, users, and evidence available to identify the priority of the incident and measures to be undertaken.

4.4 Containment

The objective of containment is to ensure that the incident does not spread or cause any additional damage. In light of the nature of the incident, the process of containment could involve disabling a compromised account, quarantining the system affected, blocking malicious communication, or limiting access.

4.5 Eradication

Eradication refers to the removal of the cause of the incident and any malicious or unauthorized behavior. It can involve the removal of the malware, resetting of any compromised credentials, removal of any unauthorized access, addressing vulnerabilities, and installing security patches.

4.6 Recovery

The purpose of recovery is the safe return of affected systems and services to their normal state. After the process of recovery, the systems should be monitored to make sure that the situation has been handled.

4.7 Lessons Learned

Once the incident has been addressed, a review of the incident should be conducted. This involves documenting what transpired, how it was managed, what went well, and what improvements could have been made. Such a process will allow for future incident management to be enhanced.

5. INCIDENT SCENARIO

This project will use an account compromise through a phishing attack as its incident scenario. Under this scenario, an employee receives an email that appears to come from a legitimate organization. The email is accompanied with a URL which redirects the employee to a fake login page.

In this fake login page, the employee logs in with his/her username and password. This information becomes available to the attacker who will use it in order to gain access to the employee's account.

The incident gets detected either because the organization detects an unauthorized login from an unfamiliar location or device. It could also be due to the fact that the employee reports the suspicious email to the security team.

After detecting the incident, the incident response team conducts the investigation in order to determine what actions have taken place.

5.1 Initial Indicators

- Suspicious email was reported by the employee.
- There was a link in the email to the suspicious login page.
- The employee entered his login details in the form.
- An unusual login attempt was noticed by the security team.
- The login was performed from an unknown location/device.
- The account could be compromised by the unauthorized person.

5.2 Potential Impact

In the case of a compromised account, an unauthorized individual could gain access to the information and services available to the account. This depends on the permissions that the compromised account has, whereby the compromise might lead to an access breach into the organization's emails, files, or other available systems.

This should be considered in the triage phase in order to determine the impact of the incident.

6. DETECTION AND IDENTIFICATION

Detection and identification is the phase where suspicious activities are detected and analyzed in order to confirm if there is a security incident. Information obtained at this stage will assist in understanding the type of incident and taking the next step.

Regarding the account compromise based on the phishing incident, the incident can be confirmed by combining user reporting and security monitoring techniques. Reporting of phishing email and suspicious login activities are among the signs that the account might be compromised.

6.1 Detection Sources

- Report from employee of suspicious email.
- Email security warning.
- Unusual log-in notification.
- Authentication and access logs.
- Security monitoring systems.
- Suspicious account activity reports.

6.2 Identification of the Incident

The security team analyzes the available data in order to see if the observed behavior qualifies as a security incident. Correlation between the phishing email, the supplied credentials, and the suspicious logon attempts is conducted during the analysis.

In case there is enough evidence that the account credentials might have been accessed by an unauthorized person, the incident will be considered a suspected account compromise. Additional investigation is needed in order to understand whether any unauthorized access took place and what actions were performed from the account.

6.3 Information to Collect

Information	Purpose
Email details	To understand the source and content of the phishing message.
Email link or attachment	To identify the suspicious resource involved in the incident.
Login time	To establish when suspicious access may have occurred.
Login location	To identify unusual access locations.
Device information	To determine whether the login came from an unfamiliar device.
Authentication logs	To review account access activity.
Account activity	To identify potentially unauthorized actions.

7. TRIAGE AND SEVERITY CLASSIFICATION

Triage comes next after the detection and identification of the incident. The objective of triage is to determine the severity of the incident, the affected systems or accounts, and the prioritization of the response steps.

In the scenario where the account is compromised through a phishing attack, the response team must find out if the credentials were really used by an unauthorized individual, if the account was indeed accessed, and if there were any systems affected by this incident.

7.1 Triage Process

1. Examine the phishing email mentioned in the report and identify the suspicious link or attachment.
2. Examine authentication logs to check any suspicious login activities.
3. Find out the time and place of the suspicious access.
4. Find out if the credentials were used successfully.
5. Examine the account's activity after the suspicious login.
6. Find out what systems, services, or information could be accessed using that account.
7. Determine the potential impact of the incident.
8. Classify the incident into an appropriate severity level.
9. Escalate the incident if required.

7.2 Severity Classification

Classification of severity is used by the incident response team to establish the urgency of handling the particular incident. Severity may be determined through a number of aspects that include:

- ➔ the significance of the compromised account
- ➔ sensitivity of the information involved
- ➔ level of unauthorized access
- ➔ possible consequences to the business.

Severity	Description	Example
Low	Limited impact with no evidence of significant unauthorized access.	Suspicious phishing email reported but credentials were not entered.
Medium	Possible unauthorized access with limited impact.	Credentials were entered and suspicious login activity was detected.
High	Confirmed unauthorized access or access to sensitive organizational resources.	A compromised account was used to access sensitive files or services.
Critical	Major compromise affecting critical systems, sensitive data, or multiple accounts.	Compromise spreads to privileged accounts or critical organizational systems.

7.3 Severity of the Selected Scenario

The initial severity level of the selected phishing attack based account compromise can be rated as medium since there was a suspicious use of credentials on a phishing page, as well as an unusual login attempt reported by the system. Yet, the level of severity might be rated as high or critical if there is any confirmation of accessing sensitive data/privileges.

8. CONTAINMENT

Containment is the act of restricting the impact of a security incident and stopping further unauthorized access to information. The primary objective of containment is to prevent the spread of the incident and allow the investigation team to carry out its investigation.

For the phishing based account compromise case study, containment entails preventing the further unauthorized use of the compromised account.

8.1 Immediate Containment Actions

1. Suspend access to the potentially compromised account in case there is any evidence of unauthorized access to the account.
2. Change the password for the account that was compromised.
3. Stop any current active sessions for the account and authentication tokens linked to it.
4. Turn on multi-factor authentication for the account wherever possible.
5. Isolate the phishing email and similar emails .
6. Block the phishing website.
7. See if the other employees have received the same phishing email.
8. Monitor the affected account for further suspicious activity.

8.2 Account Isolation

The process of account isolation includes locking down the compromised account in order to prevent further unauthorized access during the investigation. The seriousness of the situation will determine whether the account gets disabled or only its access gets limited.

Prior to performing any actions, account data and logs need to be saved in order to preserve evidence.

8.3 Containment Verification

Once all containment activities have been carried out, the team needs to ensure that unauthorized access is blocked. The authentication logs need to be analyzed for any further signs of suspicious login attempts, and the active logins need to be examined to determine whether the unauthorized logins are blocked.

The compromised account needs to be continually monitored until such time as the team is satisfied that it has been contained.

9. ERADICATION

The eradication process entails eliminating the root cause of the incident and all other malicious or unauthorized activities that were involved in the process. The main objective of eradication is ensuring that the attacker does not have access to the exploited account.

In the case of an account compromise through a phishing attack, the focus of eradication will be on securing the compromised account and correcting the weaknesses that allowed the incident to happen.

9.1 Eradication Actions

1. Password reset for the affected account.
2. End existing sessions and invalidate the authentication tokens.
3. Delete any modifications that have been done to the account.
4. Inspect and delete any abnormal email forwarding rules, if applicable.
5. Delete any unauthorized applications/authentications tied to the account.
6. Determine whether there are any other accounts affected.
7. Block any phishing sites/URLs discovered during the investigation.
8. Install any necessary security patches/security controls.
9. Examine the root cause of the phishing attack.

9.2 Credential Security

As this incident may involve credential compromise, the credentials should be considered compromised until the investigation establishes otherwise. The password needs to be updated, sessions need to be logged out, and further security measures related to authentication need to be evaluated.

In case the password was the same for any other accounts within the organization, it would also need to be examined accordingly.

10. RECOVERY

Recovery refers to the process of bringing the affected account, systems, and services to their normal state once the incident has been contained and eliminated. The process of recovery must be done cautiously in order to ensure that the incident will not recur.

With regard to the scenario where the account was compromised through phishing, the recovery step will involve restoring the affected account, checking whether security controls have been put in place, and monitoring for any other unusual activity.

10.1 Recovery Actions

1. Restore the account once containment and eradication measures have been performed.
2. Ensure that the account password has been changed properly.
3. Ensure the multi-factor authentication has been activated wherever necessary.
4. Ensure that the unauthorized sessions and authentication tokens have been revoked.
5. Look for any suspicious changes made to the account settings.
6. Look for any email forwarding rules or connected applications to the account.
7. Monitor the account after restoration to look out for any unusual activity.
8. Alert the affected employee once the account has been secured.

10.2 Post-Recovery Monitoring

Monitoring the affected account for an appropriate duration is recommended after its recovery. The authentication logs and account activities should be examined to check any odd activities. Any new suspicious activities should be investigated instantly.

The monitoring step will help ensure that the containment and eradication steps have been effective.

11. EVIDENCE COLLECTION

The process of collecting evidence plays a crucial role in incident response because it helps the response team get an understanding of what happened during the incident. The relevant information must be identified and collected properly for further analysis.

When we consider the incident of account compromise through phishing, evidence can provide us with the following information:

- The manner of phishing attack
- Usage of credentials
- Time when the unauthorized access happened
- Actions performed by the attacker

11.1 Types of Evidence

Evidence	Purpose
Phishing email	To examine the sender, subject, content, and suspicious links or attachments.
Email headers	To obtain additional information about the source and delivery of the email.
Authentication logs	To identify login attempts and unusual account access.
Account activity logs	To identify actions performed using the affected account.
Device information	To identify the device involved in suspicious access.
Security alerts	To understand alerts generated by security monitoring systems.
Screenshots	To document relevant findings during the investigation.

11.2 Evidence Preservation

Evidence should be preserved before making unnecessary modifications to the affected accounts/systems. The evidence including logs, emails, screenshots, and any other information that is available should be securely preserved without modification during the investigation process.

It is also important for the response team to document the time at which the evidence was collected, its source, and the individual who handled it.

11.3 Evidence Collection Checklist

- ☐ Preserve the reported phishing email.
- ☐ Record the date and time of the incident report.
- ☐ Preserve relevant email headers.
- ☐ Collect authentication logs.
- ☐ Review suspicious login activity.
- ☐ Record affected account information.
- ☐ Preserve relevant screenshots and alerts.
- ☐ Document all evidence collected.
- ☐ Store evidence securely.
- ☐ Record who collected and handled the evidence.

12. COMMUNICATION AND ESCALATION

Incident communication is important in the process since the relevant parties will have to be notified of the incident and any activities done to address the situation. Effective communication will facilitate effective handling of the incident and engagement of the necessary personnel.

For the incident of compromise of account through phishing attack, there should only be communication between the people responsible for the task. This will help avoid compromising organizational and user data.

12.1 Incident Communication

It is important for the incident response team to inform the necessary parties regarding the incident by providing information such as the nature of the incident, the affected account/system, the measures that have been undertaken so far, and the measures that still need to be taken.

The affected employee must be informed regarding the incident and given the appropriate instructions.

12.2 Escalation Process

Escalation becomes necessary when the incident has a significant impact or when additional resources are needed to deal with the situation. The process of escalation depends on the level of severity of the incident.

Severity	Escalation
Low	Incident response team or designated security personnel.
Medium	Security team lead and relevant IT personnel.
High	Security management and relevant organizational leadership.
Critical	Senior management, security leadership, and other required stakeholders.

12.3 Communication Guidelines

- Use only authenticated information.
- Do not communicate confidential information regarding the incident to unauthorized people.
- Maintain records of significant communications.
- Communicate significant changes in the state of the incident to relevant parties.
- Escalate the incident when the level of the incident is elevated.
- Ensure proper communication between the incident response team and users.
- Document important decisions and actions taken during the response.

12.4 Communication Record

All important communications made during the incident should be recorded to allow the response team to keep track of the actions and decisions taken during the incident.

Communication	Recipient	Purpose
Incident notification	Security team	To report and initiate investigation of the incident.
Account compromise notification	IT / Security team	To communicate the affected account and required containment actions.
User notification	Affected employee	To provide instructions and security guidance.
Escalation notification	Security management	To communicate incidents requiring higher-level attention.
Incident closure notification	Relevant stakeholders	To communicate that the incident has been resolved and recovery is complete.

13. INCIDENT RESPONSE CHECKLIST

The incident response checklist is an organized list of steps to take when dealing with a cybersecurity incident. This tool will help the team of responders ensure that certain activities are done as they detect and deal with the incident and eventually close the case.

13.1 Preparation

- ☐ Ensure that incident response procedures are available.
- ☐ Identify the responsible incident response personnel.
- ☐ Ensure that required monitoring and security tools are available.
- ☐ Maintain appropriate backup and recovery procedures.
- ☐ Establish communication and escalation procedures.

13.2 Detection and Identification

- ☐ Receive and record the incident report.
- ☐ Identify the type of suspected incident.
- ☐ Collect initial information about the incident.
- ☐ Review relevant security alerts and logs.
- ☐ Identify the affected account, system, or resource.
- ☐ Determine whether the activity represents a security incident.

13.3 Triage

- ☐ Assess the severity of the incident.
- ☐ Identify the potential impact.
- ☐ Determine the scope of the incident.
- ☐ Check whether additional accounts or systems may be affected.
- ☐ Prioritize the required response actions.
- ☐ Escalate the incident when required.

13.4 Containment

- ☐ Restrict or disable the affected account when required.
- ☐ Terminate suspicious active sessions.
- ☐ Revoke relevant authentication tokens.
- ☐ Block identified malicious or phishing resources.
- ☐ Check whether other users received the same phishing email.
- ☐ Monitor for further suspicious activity.

13.5 Eradication

- ☐ Reset compromised credentials.
- ☐ Remove unauthorized account changes.
- ☐ Check for suspicious forwarding rules or connected applications.
- ☐ Review authentication methods.
- ☐ Check for additional compromised accounts.
- ☐ Address the weaknesses that allowed the incident to occur.

13.6 Recovery

- ☐ Restore the affected account or system after containment and eradication.
- ☐ Verify that security controls are functioning correctly.
- ☐ Confirm that unauthorized sessions have been terminated.
- ☐ Monitor the affected account or system after recovery.
- ☐ Confirm that normal operations have been restored.
- ☐ Inform the affected user when appropriate.

13.7 Post-Incident Review

- ☐ Document the incident and response actions.
- ☐ Review the evidence collected during the investigation.
- ☐ Identify the root cause of the incident.
- ☐ Record lessons learned.
- ☐ Identify improvements to security controls and procedures.
- ☐ Update the incident response playbook if required.

14. INCIDENT SEVERITY RESPONSE MATRIX

The severity response matrix assists in determining the appropriate response to an incident based on the level of severity and impact of the incident. The matrix gives a quick guide of what level of priority needs to be attached to the response and any actions to be taken.

14.1 Response Priority

Severity	Priority	Initial Response	Escalation
Low	Normal	Record the incident and perform basic investigation.	Security personnel if required.
Medium	Moderate	Investigate the incident and apply containment measures.	Security team lead and relevant IT personnel.
High	High	Immediately contain the incident and investigate the affected resources.	Security management and relevant leadership.
Critical	Immediate	Initiate urgent containment and coordinate a full incident response.	Senior management and required stakeholders.

14.2 Selected Scenario Response

The initial stage of the scenario of compromising an account through a phishing attack would be classified as Medium since there is evidence that suspicious credentials have been used for logging in.

In case the evidence suggests that there was any unauthorized access to the private information or access to multiple accounts, the severity would be raised accordingly.

15. ROOT CAUSE ANALYSIS AND LESSONS LEARNED

Root cause analysis takes place after the containment and resolution of the incident so that the reasons for the occurrence of the incident can be identified. Root cause analysis helps the organization improve its security control so that such an incident does not occur again in the future.

In the selected case study, where there is an account compromise through phishing, the reason for the occurrence of this incident is that the user clicked on the phishing email and entered his credentials on the login page.

15.1 Possible Contributing Factors

- Not knowing about phishing emails.
- Not checking whether the email is legitimate and the login page is safe.
- No good authentication controls in place.
- Not monitoring suspicious login attempts.
- Password reuse across accounts, where necessary.
- Poor email filtering/phishing protection system in place.

15.2 Security Improvements

Based on the analysis of the event, there are various security measures that could be adopted to prevent such incidents.

1. Training should be done on an ongoing basis on phishing awareness among employees.
2. Multi-factor authentication should be implemented for critical accounts.
3. Email filtering and phishing prevention methods should be enhanced.
4. Anomalies in authentication processes need to be monitored carefully.
5. The reporting of phishing attempts by users needs to be encouraged.
6. Proper password management should be practiced.
7. Incident response measures should be tested periodically.

15.3 Lessons Learned

This incident shows that user awareness and technical controls both are critical to prevent account compromise. Even if a phishing email looks legitimate, it is essential for the user to validate the source before providing any credentials.

This incident also shows the importance of account activity monitoring and reacting promptly in case of abnormal access. An incident response process would be helpful in minimizing the effect of the incident.

The lessons learned from this incident must be utilized in improving security awareness, authentication controls, monitoring and incident response processes.

16. INCIDENT RESPONSE ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

Incident response can only be successful when the right responsibilities are assigned to the right people. This will enable the investigations, containment, communication, and recovery actions to be carried out effectively.

16.1 Roles

Role	Responsibility
Incident Response Team	Coordinates the overall incident response process and investigation.
Security Analyst	Reviews alerts, logs, and other evidence to identify suspicious activity.
IT Team	Performs technical actions such as account restriction, password reset, and system recovery.
Incident Response Lead	Coordinates response activities and makes decisions regarding escalation and priority.
Management	Provides necessary authorization, resources, and organizational support.
Affected User	Reports suspicious activity and follows instructions provided by the response team.

16.2 Responsibility During the Selected Scenario

Regarding the phishing account compromise, the affected employee should notify the response team of the suspicious email received. The security team should investigate the case and examine the evidence. The IT team would help in ensuring account security through password reset and ending any existing session. The IR lead should oversee the whole process and consider escalation if necessary.

17. KEY FINDINGS

The following key findings were identified from the incident response playbook and the selected phishing-based account compromise scenario.

Area	Key Finding	Security Relevance
Incident Detection	Phishing emails and unusual login activity can provide indicators of account compromise.	Helps identify suspicious activity at an early stage.
Triage	The severity of an incident depends on its impact and the extent of unauthorized access.	Helps prioritize response actions.
Containment	Restricting the affected account and terminating suspicious sessions can limit further unauthorized access.	Reduces the immediate impact of the incident.
Evidence Collection	Emails, authentication logs, account activity, and other relevant information can support investigation.	Helps determine what happened during the incident.
Eradication	Compromised credentials and unauthorized account changes need to be addressed.	Prevents continued unauthorized access.
Recovery	Monitoring the affected account after recovery helps identify recurring suspicious activity.	Confirms that the incident has been properly resolved.
Communication	Clear communication and appropriate escalation help coordinate the response.	Ensures that relevant personnel are involved.
Lessons Learned	Security weaknesses identified during the incident can be used to improve future protection.	Helps reduce the possibility of similar incidents.

18. CONCLUSION

As I worked on the project, I gained a better understanding of how the use of a structured incident response approach could be done to deal with a cybersecurity incident. The project involved various steps of incident response, ranging from the initial steps of preparation and detection all the way up to the post-incident phase.

The phishing-based account compromise incident helped me to see how an incident can be detected using user reports and security monitoring, how its level of criticality can be determined, and the response actions that can be done accordingly. Collecting evidence and communication were other crucial elements in the process.

This project helped me gain practical insights into how an incident response guidebook could assist security professionals in responding to a cybersecurity incident in a systematic manner.

19. REFERENCES

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